Team Blue - Lab 1 Outline

1. Introduction

Many college students use communication tools that are external to college systems for academic purposes. In a survey of 1,752 undergraduate students, 95.38% reported using student-created class messaging groups (le Roux & Parry, 2022). This puts an extra burden of establishing means of communication on students and is especially inconvenient for those who do not already use the same messaging apps as others. Students also prefer informal communication settings over formal platforms such as Canvas or Email (Lav et al., 2025). A solution calls for an application where course forums are automatically generated and open for the entire course duration. Classes Together will provide this solution to both students and instructors seeking a convenient correspondence method that is both academic and informal.

2. Product Description

Classes Together is a web-based platform that provides students with course-specific communities for informal academic discussion and collaboration. Students would sign in using their university credentials, select their academic institution, and browse for courses to add to their profiles. The platform would then automatically generate or locate existing communities for their selected courses, eliminating the need to manually create group chats or send invitations. These communities would allow students to ask questions, share resources, and communicate with classmates throughout the semester. The prototype will use mock enrollment data instead of a live university integration.

2.1. Key Product Features and Capabilities

- **2.1.1. Academic institution detection:** Classes Together will automatically determine a list of possible schools, universities, or educational institutions from an academic email and prompt the user to clarify the correct school.
- **2.1.2. Course Selection:** Once an institution is selected, a student can browse for their course names and add them to their profile.

2.1.3. **Automatically generate or discover course forums:** From the course information, the application will automatically generate course forums or find active ones if they already exist.

2.1.4. **Course forums match course duration:** Course forums are open for the course duration and closed afterward.

2.2. Major Components (Hardware/Software)

- **Hardware:** Student laptops, tablets, or phones with web browsers and internet access. A server or cloud hosting environment to run the platform and store data
- **Software:** A web interface, a server-sided application, and a database for user records, simulated enrollment relationships, course communities, and discussion content.
- **Major Functional Components:** The proposed system includes user authentication, a course dashboard, course communities, a discussion system, notifications, and community lifecycle management.

3. Identification of Case Study

This application is primarily for students, who will use course forums for informal assignment and study discussion. Instructors may also be interested if they also desire an informal class forum or to help students on this platform. Course organizers and academic administrators could potentially use this application by including a signup within their authored courses or otherwise recommending it to students and instructors.

4. Glossary

4.1. Canvas: A learning management system used by educational institutions to organize course materials, assignments, grades, announcements, and academic discussions.

4.2. Classes Together: A web-based platform that provides students with course-specific communities for informal academic discussions and collaboration.

4.3. Course Group: A forum for academic correspondence, designated to one class or course only.

4.4. **Email:** An electronic mailing system that is used to send emails to recipients via applications, such as Outlook and Gmail.

4.5. **Enrollment Data:** Information identifying the courses in which a student is registered during an academic term.

4.6. **Learning Management System (LMS):** - An application that is used by K-12 schools and universities to help provide students with access to the list of enrolled courses and a calendar that will help them to remember the upcoming due dates for a course enrolled for the semester.

4.7. **Mock Enrollment Data:** Simulated student registration information used to demonstrate how Classes Together would display course communities without accessing actual university enrollment records.

4.8. **Prototype:** An early working version of a software product used to demonstrate and evaluate its proposed features and functionality.

4.9. **University Credentials:** Login information provided by an educational institution that allows students to authenticate their identity when accessing university services.

4.10. **Web-Based Platform:** A software application accessed through a web browser rather than requiring users to install a dedicated application.

5. References

Lav, N. S., Schiefer, E. J., Das, S., Vancheeswaran, N., Ahmad, S., Nguyen, M., & Nicholas, A. (2025). Undergraduate learning assistants using online messaging improves student educational experiences in large neuroscience lecture courses. *Journal of Undergraduate Neuroscience Education, 23*(2), A50–A55. https://doi.org/10.59390/VWEM4773

le Roux, D. B., & Parry, D. A. (2022). An exploratory investigation of the use and effects of academic instant messaging groups among university students. *Education and Information Technologies*, *27*(1), 1055–1080. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10639-021-10631-y